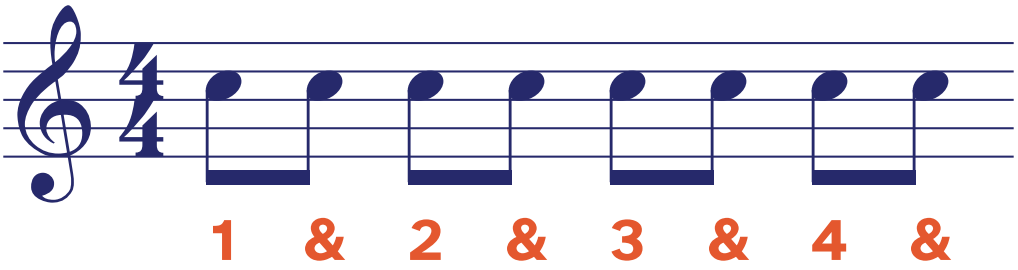
PART II · TIME · 6

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Say your own name: long and short sounds, that's **rhythm**. The pulse marches steadily on; the rhythm dances around it. How the notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats fall.

THE SECRET

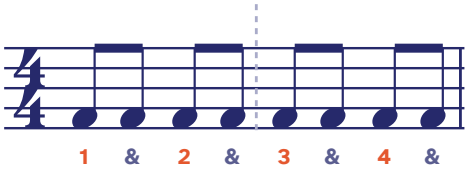
Beams group notes into beats; an upbeat borrows from the last bar.



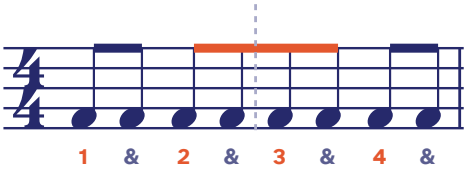
One beam, one beat

Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar (except in a deliberate grouping such as 3 + 3 + 2). In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.



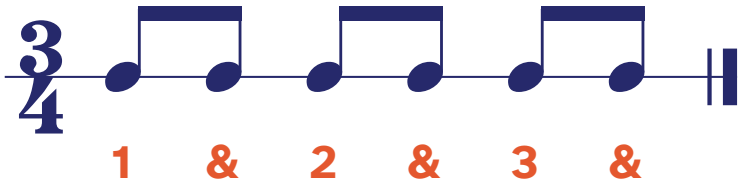
✓ beams show the beats



× a beam across the middle

EXAMPLE 1

Why are six quavers beamed in twos in 3/4?



?

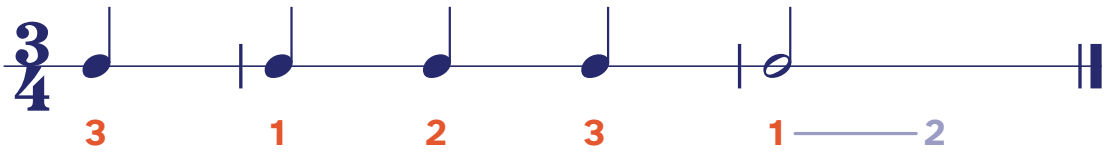
1. **How many beats** does 3/4 have, and what kind?
2. **How many quavers** fit in one beat?
3. **So how many** go under each beam?

Three crotchet beats, two quavers each: **2 + 2 + 2**. Beamed 3 + 3 they would look like 6/8.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

The upbeat (anacrusis)
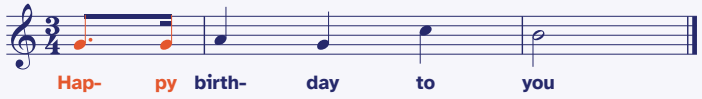
A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.



Count “1 2” silently, then play on 3. The upbeat (1 beat) and the last bar (2 beats) make one full bar.

YOU KNOW THIS

Happy Birthday

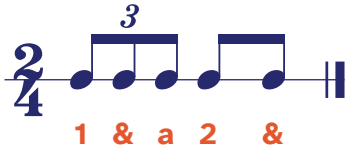


“Hap-py” comes **before** the first strong beat: an upbeat. The strong beat lands on “birth”.

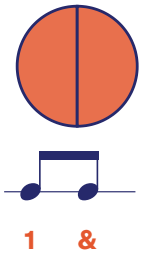
Try it. Sing it and clap only on “birth”, “day” and “you”: you feel where bar 1 starts.

THINK OF IT An upbeat is the breath before you speak: “and-ONE”. You lift on the upbeat so the strong beat can land.

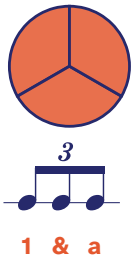
Triplets



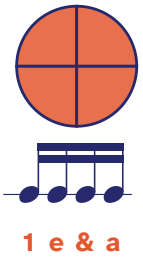
Triplet: three exactly equal notes in the time of two. First met: Grade 2.



Two quavers: one beat cut in 2



A **triplet**: one beat cut in 3

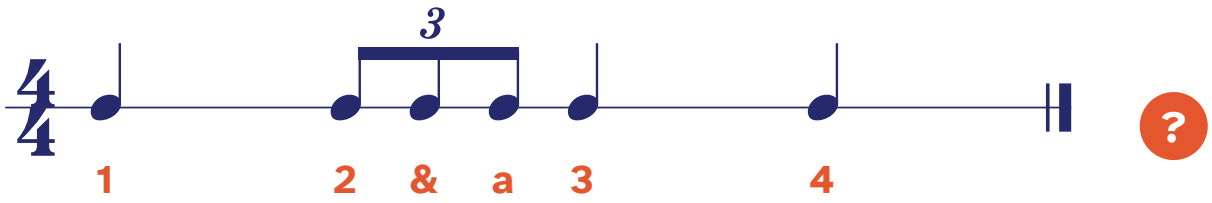


Four semiquavers: one beat cut in 4

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Where is the triplet, and how do you count it?



1. **Count the bar:** four crotchet beats.
2. **Find the little 3.** Which beat do the three quavers share?
3. **Say it:** "2 & a" on that beat.

Beat 2: "1, **2 & a**, 3, 4" (some say "trip-o-let"). Three notes squeeze into one beat; the beat never moves.

EXAMPLE 3

Count a bar of mixed values
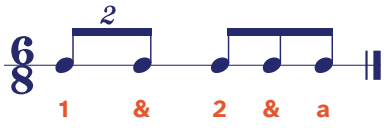


1. **Find the beats:** four crotchet beats, one per number.
2. **Beat by beat:** how many notes share each beat?
3. **Say it:** "&" for 2 notes, "e & a" for 4, "& a" for a triplet.

"1, 2 &, 3 e & a, 4 & a": crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers, a triplet. **One beat each.**

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Duplet



Two notes in the time of three, in compound time: the triplet turned inside out.

SEE ALSO

Notes and rests p. 53 · Rhythm: off the beat p. 68

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Rhythm clock